Great Wall of India



HEMANT MISHRA

Savita Punia, *33*
Goalkeeper and Captain, Indian women's hockey team

THAT AND OTHER SOBRIQUETS LIKE 'Saveita' say it all. Savita Punia is the final barrier before opposing hockey teams, her resolute figure in front of the goal post demoralising entire attacks. Against Australia in the Tokyo 2020 Olympic Games, she made nine saves to ensure the Indian women's hockey team reached its maiden semi-finals at the Olympics. Such 'sheroics' are now routine for Savita, who since late 2021 has been captaining the Women in Blue. "My team should be happy that I am their goalkeeper," she says. After leading India to bronze at the Asian Games in 2023 and recently winning the Women's Asian Champions Trophy in Ranchi, Savita has once again been nominated for FIH Goalkeeper of the Year.

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Winner of the FIH Best Goalkeeper of the Year in 2021 and 2022

Not bad for a girl who didn't pick up a hockey stick until she was 13 and only did so after being encouraged by her grandfather Ranjit Singh Punia, a farmer. Hailing from Haryana, Savita is proud that she grew up in a household where girls were not made to feel "lesser than boys". It meant that she would be packed off to Maharaja Agrasain Girls Senior Secondary School in Sirsa to pursue both hockey and English-medium schooling. When the coach suggested that she has the potential to play for India, her pharmacist father, Mahinder Singh Punia, dipped into his limited savings to buy a goalkeeper's kit worth Rs 17,000 for his daughter. "I felt if they have taken such a big step, then I should at least give it a proper try," she says. That she can now give her retired parents "a smooth, good life" is a source of joy for Savita.

Since her stellar performance at Tokyo 2020, there has been a marked interest in women's hockey. "Social media keeps people posted about us and they have expectations of us to do well, which motivates us," she says. Newly married to an Indo-Canadian businessman, Savita now has the backing of her in-laws to continue her career "as long as she wants". And Savita's passion only seems to be growing. "I don't feel tired," she says. "*Lagta hi nahin meri age ho gayi* [I don't feel I am old]. I feel energetic and want to improve and play better." ■

–Suhani Singh

MANTRA FOR SUCCESS

"You never stop learning. I can never say I am perfect, that I know everything. Learning only makes you better"

↘ PRE-GAME RITUAL
Entering the field with the right foot first, a suggestion by her mother

↘ IF NOT HOCKEY...
Savita would have pursued medicine, her father's dream for her